Vorontsov, the Soviet ambassador to India, had requested an urgent meeting with the PM or the external affairs minister (EAM) to pass a message from Soviet president, Leonid Brezhnev. Neither of the two was available at that hour. Could Sathe please meet Vorontsov, asked the JS? The meeting was fixed for just before midnight. Moscow had agreed to an Afghan request for support to stop external (US, Chinese, and Pakistani) interference and aggression, Vorontsov explained to Sathe. It was done on the basis of the 1978 Soviet-Afghan Treaty of Friendship and Article 51 of the UN Charter. Sathe noted without making any official comment. India by this point had intelligence that a Soviet armored column had closed-in on Kabul in the wee hours of Christmas Day. What bothered Sathe, at least as much if not more than the Soviet action itself, was the fact that Moscow had not bothered consulting the Indian leadership before taking the decision. PM Charan Singh and EAM Shyam Nandan Mishra were briefed about the late-night drama next morning. India's ambassador to Moscow, I K Gujral, also had no idea of the invasion till it actually occurred.[6] After four days, on 31 December 1979, the Soviet ambassador was summoned to the PMO.[7]

Having brushed the Afghan question aside (like many other foreign policy issues) throughout his 'caretaking' premiership, Charan Singh now faced an unenviable dilemma. Should India support Soviet actions in Afghanistan or not? Extending support would undermine the principle of non-alignment and marginalise New Delhi among its Asian and African partners at the NAM. Relations with the people of Afghanistan and the larger Islamic world would also suffer. There were also concerns that the Soviet juggernaut, instead of stopping in Afghanistan, may venture into Balochistan—which already had separatist tendencies—in order to access South Asian warm water ports.[8] If such an eventuality ever occurred, India's own sovereignty would be under threat. But if India decided to criticise Soviet actions, it would jeopardise support on Kashmir and a constant supply of Soviet defence equipment and oil. A hike in global oil prices in 1979 and a severe drought that reduced agricultural production by 12.5 per cent had plummeted India's growth rate by a sharp 5.2 per cent within a year.[9] With its economy structured around the socialistic five-year planning cycles and deeply linked to the Soviet Union, Moscow's economic support was necessary. Moreover, in light of Soviet support during the 1971 India-Pakistan war,